ERA 15

World War I: The Great War

1914 – 1918

Causes · neutrality · America's entry & victory

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

How did a European war become an American war—and an American victory?

KEY TERMS

The M.A.I.N. causes · neutrality · the Lusitania · the Zimmermann Telegram · the A.E.F.

ALIGNED TO

CED Topic 7.5 · AMSCO Ch. 7.5

HOW THE WORLD WENT TO WAR

The Great War

The M.A.I.N. Causes

I

Militarism & Alliances

An arms race and rival **alliances** split Europe into two armed camps.

II

Imperialism

Competition for colonies bred rivalry among the great powers.

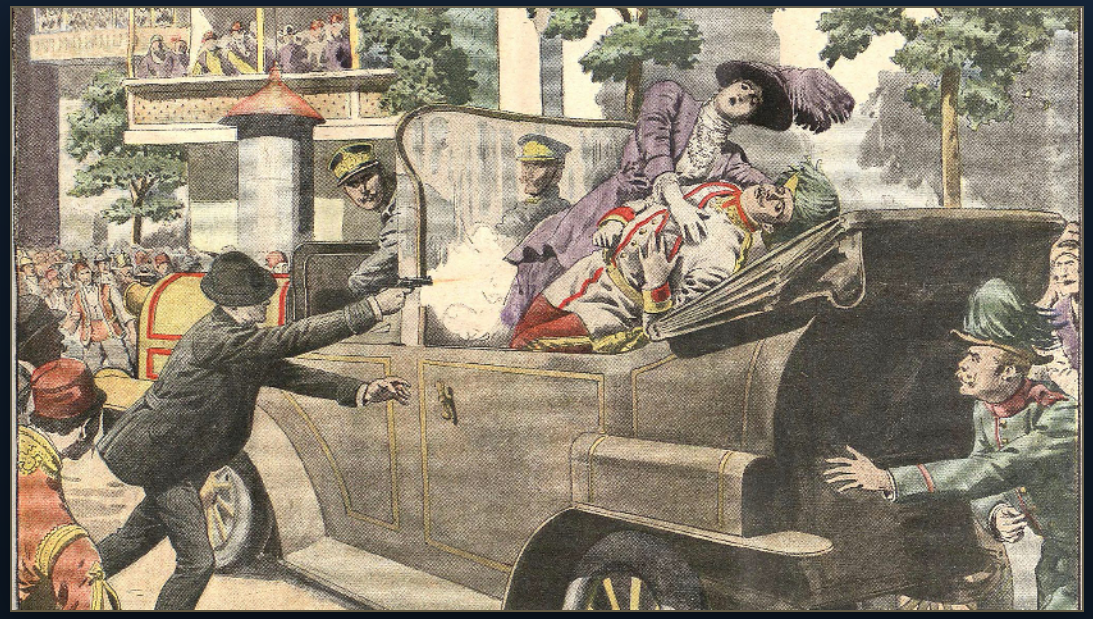
III

Nationalism

Ethnic pride and ambition—especially in the Balkans—lit the fuse.

Sarajevo, 1914

The Spark



- In June 1914, a Serbian nationalist assassinated **Archduke Franz Ferdinand** of Austria-Hungary.
- The killing triggered the tangle of European **alliances**.
- Within weeks, the great powers were at war.

Europe Erupts

ASSASSINATION

A Single Shot

Franz Ferdinand is killed in Sarajevo.

→

ALLIANCES

The Dominoes Fall

Central Powers vs. **Allied Powers**—all of Europe mobilizes.

→

STALEMATE

Trench Warfare

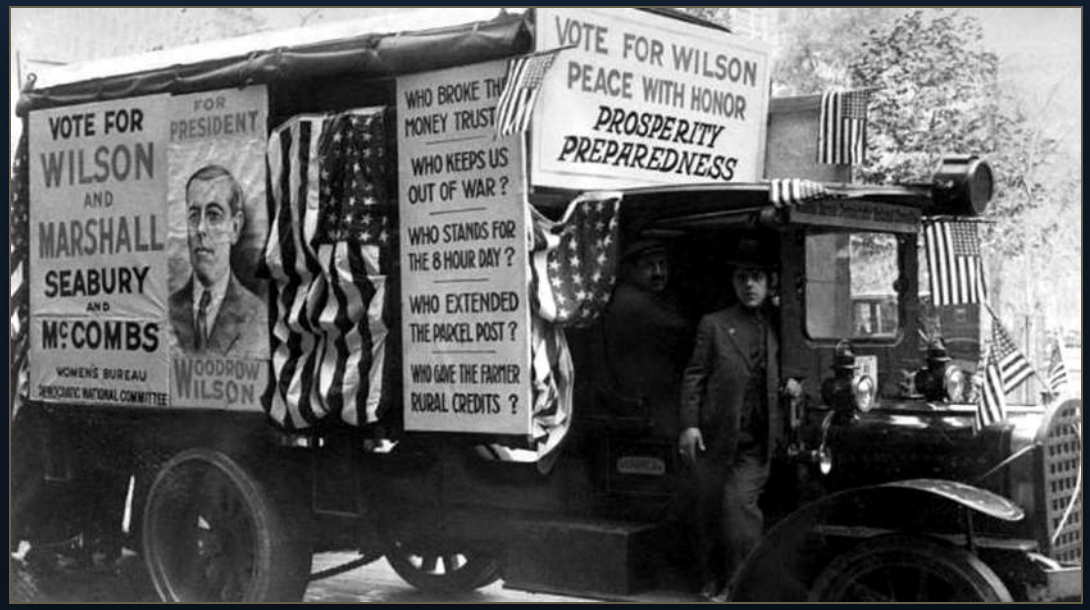
Machine guns and trenches turn the **Western Front** into a bloody deadlock.

SECTION

America's Road to War

American Neutrality

- President **Wilson** urged Americans to stay '**neutral** in thought and deed.'
- He won re-election in 1916 on the slogan 'He kept us out of war.'
- Yet U.S. trade and loans increasingly favored the Allies.



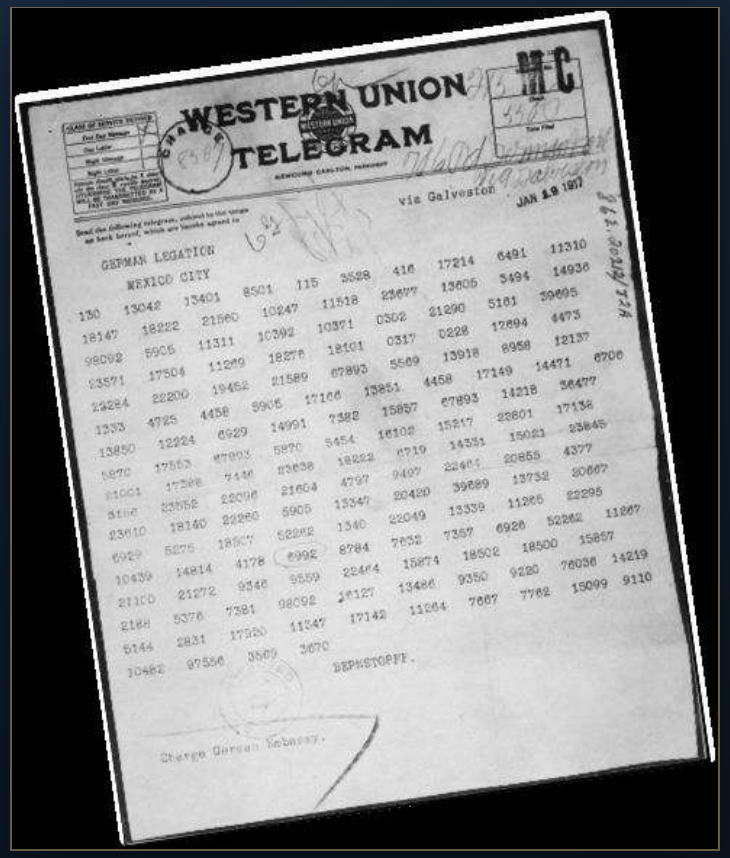
The Lusitania & the U-Boats



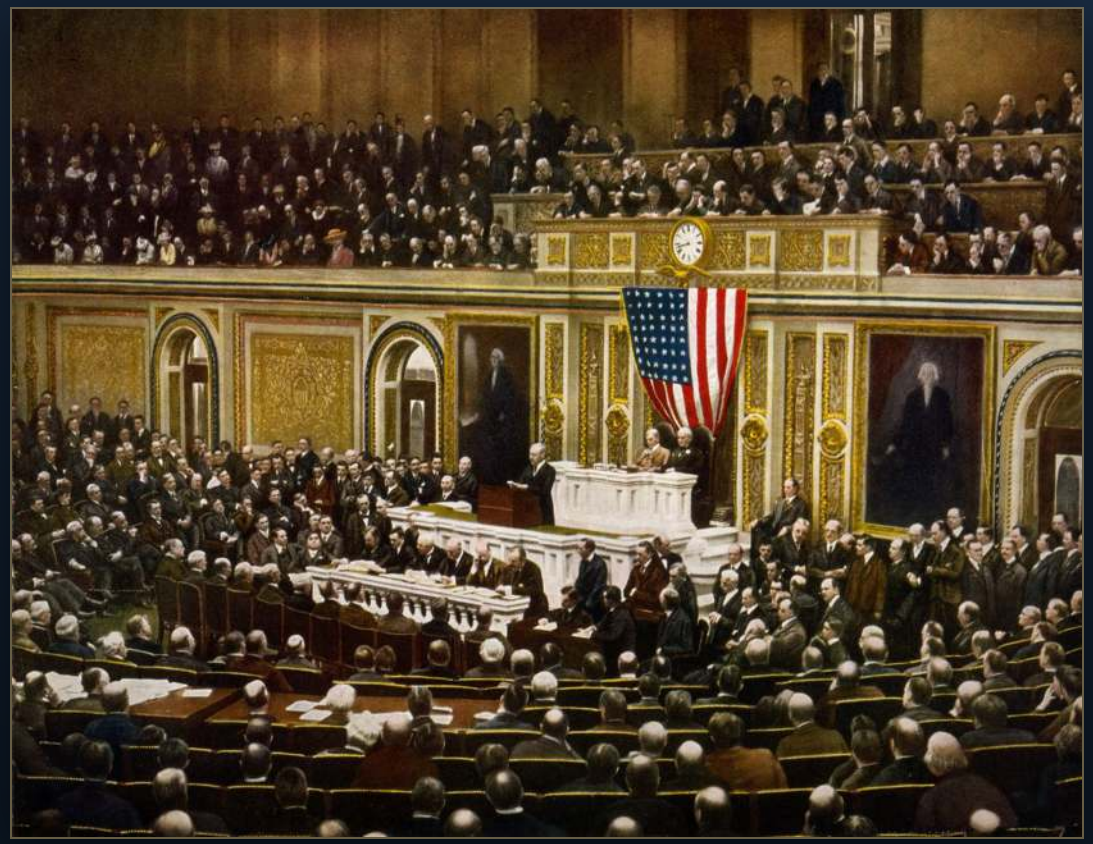
- Germany waged **unrestricted submarine warfare** with its **U-boats**.
- In 1915 a **U-boat** sank the ***Lusitania***—killing 1,198, including 128 Americans.
- Outrage grew, but Wilson kept the U.S. out—for the moment.

The Zimmermann Telegram

- In early 1917, Germany resumed **unrestricted submarine warfare**.
- The **Zimmermann Telegram** revealed a German plot urging **Mexico** to attack the U.S.
- American opinion turned decisively toward war.



America Declares War



- In April 1917, Wilson asked Congress to declare war on Germany.
- The U.S. would fight to '**make the world safe for democracy**.'
- America entered the Great War.

SECTION

Over There

Mobilizing for War

- The **Selective Service Act** drafted nearly 3 million men.
- The **American Expeditionary Force**, led by **General Pershing**, sailed to France.
- Fresh American '**doughboys**' poured onto the **Western Front**.



Victory & Armistice



- By 1918, U.S. troops helped halt the final German offensive.
- Their numbers and morale tipped the balance to the Allies.
- On November 11, 1918, the guns fell silent—the **armistice** ended the war.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

World War I: The Great War

1. The **M.A.I.N. causes** turned the assassination of **Franz Ferdinand** into a catastrophic world war.
2. German **submarine warfare**, the **Lusitania**, and the **Zimmermann Telegram** drew a reluctant America into the war in **April 1917**.
3. The **A.E.F.** under **Pershing** tipped the balance, and the **armistice** ended the fighting on November 11, 1918.

DISCUSS & APPLY

World War I: The Great War

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

CAUSATION

Explain how the **M.A.I.N. causes** turned an assassination into a world war.

CONTEXTUALIZATION

Why did the U.S. abandon **neutrality** and enter the war in 1917?

COMPARISON

Compare American attitudes toward **intervention** in 1914 and 1917. What changed?

Up next — **Lesson 36: The Home Front & the Peace** (mobilization, the Great Migration & the League)